

3.2 Comparative dramatic interpretation

Paper 3 Shakespeare and Drama · 2026 examination · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

At A Level consider how dramatic form, contexts and different critical interpretations illuminate the chosen set texts without turning context into an unrelated history essay. Compare effects through evidence and the question's exact terms. Evaluate readings by asking which scene details they clarify and which they overlook.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

A protagonist's silence can suggest fear, strategy or resistance; assess each reading against preceding lines, stage directions and what follows.

Original practice stimulus

On the public platform a woman was accused of taking the documents. She answered with silence and watched the mayor fold his paper into smaller and smaller squares. The crowd read her stillness as guilt; her brother later called it courage. When the hall emptied, she told a friend, "I could have spoken, but every answer would have named someone else." She placed the documents on the table without opening them. The private sentence might support a protective motive, but it also delays a full explanation. Consider how a performance might make her silence fearful, strategic or defiant without changing the words of the scene.

Extended response

Compose your response in the space provided and support your interpretation with evidence.

1 Original prompt: A character refuses to answer a public accusation but speaks freely [25]
alone afterward. Explore two interpretations of the silence and the dramatic contrast.

Check: relevant evidence · coherent argument · accurate and deliberate language

Answers and explanation

Question 1 [25 marks]

A strong answer weighs fear against deliberate resistance, analyses audience access to later private speech, and treats performance choices as plausible alternatives. Transfer the method to the set drama text with precise references.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or calculation error; then retry without looking at the solution.

Syllabus: Literature in English 9695, 2024–2026.

<https://www.cambridgeinternational.org/Images/636097-2024-2026-syllabus.pdf>

Original FagusED teaching material. Question layout and mark presentation informed by the May/June 2026 papers supplied by the user. The practice question is newly written and is not a Cambridge past-paper question.